

Matthai referred quite prominently to the "Indianization of our superior staff", a big demand of nationalist leaders during the freedom movement. In the Budget, he noted that, of the 388 European railway officers employed in important positions, about 50 per cent were due to leave or had left. Creating an Indian workforce that could take on these senior positions was of utmost urgency. A beginning had already been made towards the end of 1947 when, of six Railway Board members, five were Indian. This was a far cry from the start of that year, when four Europeans and one Indian made up the Board. The transition to a network staffed completely by Indians was seamless even as the railways continued to operate efficiently. A lack of skilled labour also became an issue to be resolved with some urgency, especially since different communities specialized in certain roles within the railways and these forces were now irretrievably divided.

"For instance," wrote Canadian historian Ian J Kerr, "Muslims often worked with locomotives or in the workshops, while Hindus and Sikhs were more common in traffic or clerical roles. The Partition led to a severe imbalance in the workforce. It would be several years before this imbalance would be properly addressed."